



SE. Asia

Hang Son Doong

A recently discovered limestone cave system of immense scale, situated within jungle-covered mountains in a remote part of Vietnam

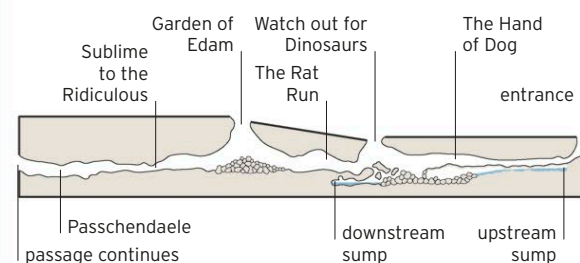
One of the largest cave systems discovered on Earth, Hang Son Doong is up to 820 ft (250 m) high, 660 ft (200 m) wide, and stretches a total of 5½ miles (9 km). Located near the Laos border in central Vietnam, it is part of a network of around 150 caves within the Annamite Mountains. First discovered in 1991, Hang Son Doong was unexplored until 2009.

Mountain river cave

Meaning “mountain river cave,” Hang Son Doong has been carved out of some of the oldest limestone in Asia by the fast-flowing Rao Thuong River over the last 2–5 million years. Giant openings (dolines), created as massive sections of the ceiling collapsed, have allowed areas of vegetation to develop, including trees up to 100 ft (30 m) tall. These are dwarfed by some of the stalagmites found within the cave, which, at more than 245 ft (75 m) high, are the largest on Earth.

CHAMBERS AND PASSAGES

The Hang Son Doong system is straight, relatively flat, and lacks side passages. This is due to the fact that it has formed along a fault in the limestone. It has many discrete sections and remarkable features, often with evocative names. These include the Hand of Dog, a huge, dog-paw-shaped stalagmite, and the two forested areas, Watch out for Dinosaurs and the Garden of Edam.



Hang Son Doong is **so large** that it has its **own microclimate**, including **wind and clouds**



◁ EARTHLY TREASURES

Calcite deposits called cave pearls are found in parts of the cave. Usually less than ½ in (1 cm) wide, here they are the size of oranges.

△ GREEN COVER

Around the borders of the open sections, where dim light reaches the ground, colonies of ferns and algae cover terraces of limestone.